Brinewright

Executive Summary: Brinewright

Problem

Fermented vegetables such as sauerkraut, kimchi and pickled carrots are popular, and many people say they want to make them at home. Yet a large share of those people never start. In informal conversations with about forty classmates, neighbors and relatives, the most common reason was fear: fear of using the wrong amount of salt, fear of mold, and fear of not being able to tell whether a batch is safe to eat. Existing recipes online give conflicting advice, and most assume the reader already knows what a healthy ferment looks like. Teachers face a similar barrier. Fermentation is a natural way to teach microbiology and chemistry, but few teachers have the time to source materials, test recipes and write safety instructions on their own.

Solution

Brinewright sells small-batch fermentation kits designed to take the intimidation out of the process. Every kit includes a glass jar with an airlock lid, salt pre-measured for the specific vegetable and quantity, pH test strips so users can confirm that their ferment has reached a safe acidity, and a day-by-day printed guide with photographs showing what normal and abnormal batches look like. The guide ends with a clear rule for when to eat and when to discard.

We offer two versions. The Home Kit is delivered monthly or bought one at a time, with a rotating seasonal vegetable and flavor theme. The Classroom Kit contains materials for a group of up to thirty students, along with lesson plans for middle and high school science units, observation worksheets, and a teacher safety checklist. Both versions include access to an online guide where users can compare photographs of their batches against reference images.

Market

We believe the market includes two groups. The first is home cooks interested in gut health, flavor and food projects, a group that has grown alongside interest in sourdough baking and home pickling. The second is the school science market, where teachers are looking for hands-on activities that connect to curriculum standards. We have not yet completed a formal market study. As a rough estimate, if a small fraction of adults who say they are interested in fermenting actually bought a kit each year, the Home Kit market would be in the tens of millions of dollars nationally. For schools, there are tens of thousands of middle and high schools in the country, and we assume a small share might spend a modest classroom supply budget on a product like ours. We plan to start in our own region, where we can deliver quickly and meet customers in person, before shipping nationally.

Business Model

We plan to earn revenue from three sources. The Home Kit would sell for about twenty-eight dollars as a single purchase or twenty-four dollars per month as a subscription. The Classroom Kit would sell for about ninety dollars per class set. We also hope to sell refill packs of salt and test strips to returning customers. Based on our prototype costs, we estimate that materials and packaging for a Home Kit come to roughly eleven dollars, with shipping adding another six to eight dollars, which leaves a modest margin. We expect costs to fall with larger orders from suppliers, although we have not yet received firm quotes at volume. We plan to reach customers mainly through social media, cooking communities, and direct outreach to teachers, and we have not yet worked out what it will cost us to acquire a customer.

Competition

The space is crowded. Several companies sell fermentation crocks, airlock lids and starter cultures, and a number of meal kit and pantry subscription services have offered pickling or fermenting boxes as limited editions. Cookbooks, video channels and online forums offer free

instruction. Science supply companies already sell general classroom kits. We think Brinewright differs in focusing on safety and confidence rather than on equipment or recipes alone, and in serving both home and classroom users with the same core product. We recognize that a larger competitor could copy our approach, and that our main advantage today is our focus and our willingness to test closely with beginners.

Team

Maya Okonkwo-Reyes is a senior studying food science and leads product development and safety testing. She has two years of experience working in a campus food lab and designed the salt ratios and pH checkpoints used in our prototype. Daniel Ferreira Lindqvist is a junior in business administration and leads operations, supplier contacts and pricing. He previously ran a small online resale shop and handled its shipping. Priya Venkataraghavan is a senior in science education and leads the classroom materials, drawing on student teaching placements in two middle schools. We have not yet recruited an advisor with experience in food regulation or consumer packaged goods, and we know this is a gap.

Milestones and Financials

To date we have defined the core concept, built a working prototype kit, and made our first batches in our own kitchens and a campus lab. We registered the venture name with our university's entrepreneurship program, though we have not yet formed a legal entity. Twelve home cooks and one middle school science class have used early versions of the kit, and we collected written feedback from most of them. Participants generally said that the pH strips and photo guide made them feel more confident, and several asked for more flavor options. We have not yet charged for any kit, so we have no revenue. Our spending so far, about nine hundred dollars, came from the founders' personal savings and covered jars, salt, strips and printing. We do not yet have a website.

What We Are Asking For

We are applying for competition funding of up to ten thousand dollars. We would use roughly four thousand dollars for a first production run of one hundred Home Kits and twenty Classroom Kits, three thousand dollars for legal formation, basic liability insurance and food safety review, two thousand dollars for a simple website and ordering system, and the remainder for testing and shipping. Beyond funding, we are seeking mentorship from judges or alumni with experience in food products, regulatory compliance and direct-to-consumer sales, as well as introductions to teachers and school purchasing contacts. Our goal over the next six months is to sell out the first run, learn what customers will actually pay, and decide whether the home or the classroom market should be our main focus.